STAYMAN CONVENTION

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

STAYMAN CONVENTION SUMMARY

When one partner opens 1NT it is difficult to uncover a 4-4 Major fit using only natural bidding. The Stayman Convention solves the problem and improves bidding accuracy as well. As an additional benefit, when you use Stayman the 1NT Opener usually becomes the Declarer on the hand, thereby keeping the stronger hand concealed.

The Stayman Convention is worthwhile even if it is the only convention you use. However, there are added benefits to using Stayman in conjunction with Jacoby Transfers. The two work smoothly together with Stayman taking care of those hands where Responder has a 4-card Major(s) and Jacoby Transfers taking care of those hands where Responder has a 5- or 6-card Major.

The actual working of Stayman is simple:
Following a 1NT opening, Responder will only use Stayman when he holds at least one 4-card Major suit.
He does so by bidding 2♣ which requires Opener to reply as follows:

- With no 4-card Major suit he bids 2♦.
- With a 4-card ♥ suit, (and possibly 4 ♠s as well), he bids 2♥.
- With a 4-card ♠ suit, (but not 4 ♥s), he bids 2♠.

It really is as simple as that. Well, almost.

Stayman takes much of the guesswork (sometimes called judgement) out of the bidding and steers you directly to these two goals:

1. With a partnership 26 points you will reach game, with 33 you will reach slam.
2. With a partnership 8+ cards in a Major suit you will play in that suit, otherwise you will play notrump.

For the first point consider this table which is based on the 1NT opener holding 15-17 points.

Resp Points	Opener Points			Bidding Target
	15	16	17	
8	23	24	25	Partscore
9	24	25	26	
10	25	26	27	
11	26	27	28	
12	27	28	29	Game
13	28	29	30	
14	29	30	31	
15	30	31	32	
16	31	32	33	
17	32	33	34	Slam
18	33	34	35	

Responder's actions are as follows:

- 8 points or fewer - usually pass, but may use Stayman and then pass
- 9 points - invite partner to game
- 10 points - either invite or force to game, using your judgement
- 11-15 points - force to game
- 16 points - invite to slam
- 17 points - either invite or force to slam, using your judgement
- 18 points or more - force to slam

Opener's actions are as follows:

- 15 points - decline invitations
- 16 points - either decline or accept, using your judgement
- 17 points - accept invitations

As to the second point above (the 8-card trump fit) Responder is usually in charge.

- If Opener shows a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks that suit.
- If Opener does not show a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks notrump.

Opener usually has no say in the suit selection, with this important exception:
If Opener holds 4 cards in **EACH** Major suit he responds 2♥.
Should Responder then bid notrump, indicating a dislike for ♥s, Opener should bid ♠s because she knows there is a 4-4 ♠ fit,

Some comments are in order about the point count methods used on these pages.
Initial point count for both hands is based on 4-3-2-1 plus one point for a fifth card in a suit.
Revalued points (only after a trump fit is discovered) are +1 for a doubleton, +2 for a singleton and +3 for a void. Both hands should count these revalued short-suit points; Opener of course would not have a singleton or void.

One more point. Stayman should definitely be used after 2NT openings as well.

25 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣3

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦2

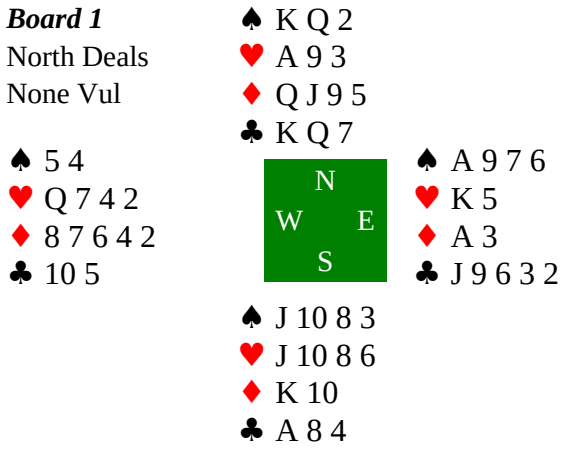
Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣J

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣5

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul



West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♣3

You open 1NT and partner responds 2♣.

With no 4-card Major you reply 2♦. What do you bid after partner next says 2NT?

Partner seems to have about 9 points and is inviting you to say 3NT. Since you have a maximum 17 point hand you accept the invitation.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A J 4
♥ K 10 7
♦ 10 8 6 4
♣ 10 9 3

♠ K 10 8 5
♥ 9 8 5 2
♦ A 9 3
♣ Q 5



♠ Q 7 6 2
♥ Q 6 3
♦ K Q J
♣ A J 7

♠ 9 3
♥ A J 4
♦ 7 5 2
♣ K 8 6 4 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♠			
All Pass			

3♠ by East
Lead: ♦2

You open 1NT and partner responds 2♣.

You bid 2♠. Partner next says 3♠.

Considering the bidding you have done so far you couldn't have a worse hand. With 4-3-3-3 distribution and a bare 15 points you most certainly don't want to accept any invitation from partner. So you pass. As you see, 9 tricks are not going to come easily.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 10 9 3 ♥ K 8 7 3 ♦ A 5 ♣ 7 6 4	
♠ 8 7 5 4 ♥ Q 4 ♦ 10 9 8 ♣ J 10 9 8		♠ A K ♥ J 6 2 ♦ 7 6 3 2 ♣ K 5 3 2
	♠ J 6 2 ♥ A 10 9 5 ♦ K Q J 4 ♣ A Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♣J

You open 1NT and partner responds 2♣.

You respond 2♥. Partner now says 3♥.

Partner has told you he has 4 ♥s and approximately 9 points. Add that to your 4 ♥s and 17 points and the total equals a game bid in ♥s. So you say 4♥.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 7 5 3 2 ♥ 8 4 2 ♦ K 9 ♣ 7 6 5 4	
♠ K Q J 4 ♥ A 10 9 5 ♦ J 7 3 ♣ A Q		♠ A 10 9 6 ♥ 6 3 ♦ Q 10 8 4 ♣ K 8 3
	♠ 8 ♥ K Q J 7 ♦ A 6 5 2 ♣ J 10 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	2NT	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♣5

You open 1NT and partner responds 2♣.

When you have 4 cards in both Majors you respond 2♥. Partner bids 2NT. What is your next bid?

Partner would never bid Stayman without a 4-card Major. Since he did not like your ♥ bid it is clear that his 4-card Major must be ♠s. His 2NT bid was an invitation for you to bid 3NT, which means he has about 9 points. Knowing that partner has 9 points and 4 ♠s, your call is clear : 4♠.